

How Uncertainty Becomes Certainty

Representational Hardening and Reality Drift

Reality Drift Framework — Representational Systems Brief #4

A. Jacobs

The Basic Pattern

Information rarely becomes false all at once.

More often, it becomes progressively more certain as it moves through systems.

Observations become summaries.

Summaries become evidence.

Evidence becomes guidelines.

Guidelines become policy.

Policy becomes accepted reality.

The basic sequence is:

observation → summary → interpretation → standardization → institutionalization → accepted truth

At each step, uncertainty decreases.

Confidence increases.

Reality does not necessarily become better understood.

Where Certainty Comes From

Every observation begins with uncertainty.

It contains context, ambiguity, unanswered questions, and alternative explanations.

To become useful, that uncertainty is gradually reduced.

A summary emphasizes the main finding.

An interpretation explains what it means.

A guideline recommends what should be done.

A policy standardizes the recommendation.

Eventually, people encounter the conclusion without ever encountering the original observation.

The representation becomes more stable than the evidence that produced it.

Representational Hardening

Representational hardening is the process by which provisional representations gradually become treated as fixed reality.

Nothing necessarily becomes false.

The original uncertainty simply disappears.

Possibilities become probabilities.

Probabilities become recommendations.

Recommendations become rules.

Rules become assumptions.

The representation feels increasingly objective because its history has been compressed away.

Why the Gap Widens

Each transformation is reasonable on its own.

Each removes a small amount of uncertainty.

No individual step creates a major distortion.

But the changes accumulate.

The final representation may still point toward reality while no longer communicating how tentative, conditional, or incomplete the original evidence actually was.

The cleaner the representation becomes, the harder it is to question.

Reality Drift

Within the **Reality Drift framework**, drift begins when systems become more responsive to hardened representations than to ongoing observation.

New evidence competes with established policy.

Direct experience competes with accepted practice.

Current reality competes with inherited certainty.

The system remains coherent because every layer agrees with the layer above it.

The original uncertainty has vanished.

Why This Happens Everywhere

The same pattern appears across science, medicine, journalism, education, AI, organizations, and public policy.

Research becomes best practices.

Best practices become compliance.

Compliance becomes institutional memory.

Institutional memory becomes common sense.

The process creates stability.

It also makes correction progressively more difficult.

The Core Principle

Civilizations cannot function without reducing uncertainty.

The danger begins when uncertainty disappears from the representation but not from reality.

Over time, confidence accumulates faster than evidence.

The representation becomes easier to defend than to reexamine.

Reality Drift begins when inherited certainty becomes more authoritative than renewed observation.

The cleaner a representation becomes, the easier it is to mistake it for reality.

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